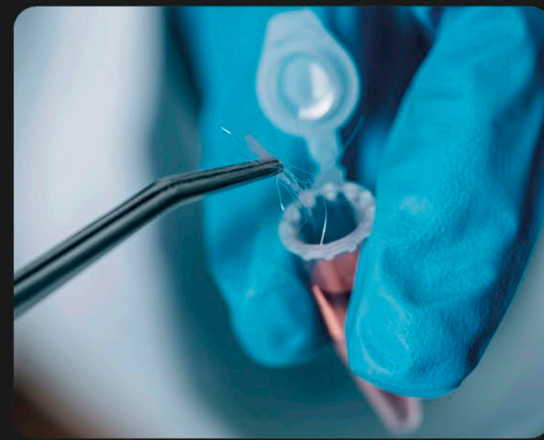
1 The scene of the crime
Forensic specialists comb crime scenes for samples of DNA by looking for traces of blood, saliva, and hair, and by collecting clothes and other items. Everything a person has touched could have their DNA on it.

The DNA inside a human cell would be 6.5 ft (2 m) long if fully stretched out.



2 Collecting samples
Anything that could contain DNA, such as hair, is carefully collected and sent to specialists. Swabs are also taken from any suspects, from which their DNA can be extracted for comparison.

3 In the lab
Once the samples arrive in the lab, scientists extract the DNA from cells in the root of the hairs and multiply it so there is enough to analyze. This DNA is run through machines that can read the unique genetic code it contains.

4 Analyzing the DNA
A person's DNA acts like a fingerprint, and scientists can make a printout of its unique code. The DNA from the crime scene can then be compared to the DNA of suspects to look for any matches.